Most crowded country in Europe?

An AFP feature, tested against World Bank, Eurostat and Planning Authority data

THE CLAIM

"The tiny Mediterranean island is the most densely populated country in Europe."

Agence France-Presse (AFP), 6 June 2026

AFP's own voice, in a feature on development in Malta.

Three statements checked: density, approvals and population growth.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

Right for the EU; Monaco is denser. Population and approvals hold.

SUPPORTED | **LARGELY SUPPORTED** | NOT SUBSTANTIATED | MISLEADING | CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

1,805

People per km², 2024

Highest in the EU, 3.4 times the Netherlands (534). Monaco: 18,537.

+30.9%

Population, 2015–2025

AFP says "nearly 30 percent". 2016–2026: +30.8%.

12,325

Dwelling units approved, 2025

Up 41% on 2024 and 4.6 times 2013, but below the 2018–2019 peaks.

2nd

Of 44 European states

Malta ranks second in the World Bank list, after Monaco. Vatican City not tested.

FAIR TO SAY

Malta is by far the densest EU country; "in Europe" needs the words "after Monaco".

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

- ☐ AFP: which measure of "approvals".
- ☐ Planning Authority: approvals of new buildings by year.
- ☐ Readers: say "in the EU" when you mean it.